

3.3 Population Growth by District

To study population growth at the district level, data from the 2024 Census are presented together with data from the previous census years 1981, 2001, and 2012 in Table 3.3.

Table 3.3 : Population and Average Annual Growth Rate by District, Census Years 1981- 2024

District	Population				Average Annual Growth Rate (%)			
	1981 ²	2001 ³	2012	2024	1981-2001	1981-2012	2001-2012	2012-2024
Sri Lanka	14,846,274	18,797,257	20,359,439	21,781,800	1.2	1.0	0.7	0.5
Colombo	1,675,847	2,239,696	2,324,349	2,375,415	1.4	1.1	0.3	0.2
Gampaha	1,367,813	2,060,470	2,304,833	2,436,142	2.0	1.7	1.0	0.4
Kalutara	823,964	1,065,635	1,221,948	1,305,784	1.3	1.3	1.3	0.5
Kandy	1,032,335	1,276,202	1,375,382	1,461,895	1.0	0.9	0.7	0.5
Matale	352,860	439,031	484,531	526,870	1.1	1.0	0.9	0.7
Nuwara Eliya	583,716	702,689	711,644	725,280	0.9	0.6	0.1	0.1
Galle	805,403	989,769	1,063,334	1,097,372	1.0	0.9	0.7	0.2
Matara	642,235	760,990	814,048	837,889	0.8	0.8	0.6	0.2
Hambantota	421,277	525,913	599,903	671,418	1.1	1.1	1.2	0.9
Jaffna	734,474	-	583,882	594,751	-	-0.7	-	0.1
Mannar	105,276	-	99,570	123,756	-	-0.2	-	1.7
Vavuniya	93,694	-	172,115	172,312	-	2.0	-	0.0
Mullaitivu	73,886	-	92,238	122,619	-	0.7	-	2.2
Kilinochchi	90,778	-	113,510	136,710	-	0.7	-	1.4
Batticaloa	329,343	-	526,567	595,918	-	1.5	-	1.0
Ampara	383,275	592,596	649,402	744,551	2.1	1.7	0.9	1.1
Trincomalee	250,771	-	379,541	442,745	-	1.3	-	1.2
Kurunegala	1,198,795	1,458,385	1,618,465	1,768,156	1.0	1.0	1.0	0.7
Puttalam	485,619	709,002	762,396	818,816	1.9	1.5	0.7	0.6
Anuradhapura	575,546	742,535	860,575	960,080	1.3	1.3	1.4	0.9
Polonnaruwa	253,411	358,804	406,088	447,530	1.7	1.5	1.2	0.8
Badulla	620,839	778,422	815,405	872,307	1.1	0.9	0.4	0.5
Moneragala	269,684	396,521	451,058	527,585	1.9	1.7	1.2	1.2
Ratnapura	779,927	1,016,221	1,088,007	1,145,423	1.3	1.1	0.6	0.4
Kegalle	678,456	784,371	840,648	870,476	0.7	0.7	0.6	0.3

During the period from 1981 to 2024, the population of Sri Lanka increased from 14.8 million to 21.8 million. Considering the census period 2012–2024, the highest average annual growth rate (2.2%) was reported in the Mullaitivu District, which is also reported as the district with the lowest resident population.

² The data for Jaffna and Kilinochchi Districts in the 1981 Census are presented according to the current district boundaries

³ In the 2001 Census, enumeration was not fully completed in the districts of Jaffna, Mannar, Vavuniya, Mullaitivu, Kilinochchi, Batticaloa, and Trincomalee. Therefore, after estimating the population for these districts, the total estimated population for the entire country, as calculated at the end, is reported under 2001.